

THE GRASP

Written by: Cory Armer

Phone: 512-412-1762
E-mail: coryarmer@gmail.com

WGA Registration: 2316023

ACT ONE

SCENE 1

INT. APARTMENT - MORNING

A digital alarm clock BUZZES, loud and shrill, and doesn't stop. It keeps going until it's the only thing in the room.

LENA (late 20s) flings the sheet aside, naked and unselfconscious, and gropes across the nightstand until her palm finds plastic. She slams the alarm off.

It isn't really silent after. The apartment hums with old wiring, and the pipes tick in the wall. It's a small place, lived in and tired: curtains sagging against dirty windows, laundry piled on a chair, and a stack of unopened mail on the counter, the top envelope striped red with FINAL NOTICE.

In the kitchenette, JONAS (early 30s) is already up in boxers and bare feet, hunched over a laptop while the coffee maker gurgles into a stained mug.

Lena sits on the edge of the bed with her spine curved and her hair in her face, just breathing.

LENA
(thick with sleep)
What time is it?

JONAS
Late.

He doesn't look up from the screen.

Lena staggers to the bathroom and the shower hisses on. Through the cracked door there's steam and the slap of water on tile, and her hand flat against the wall while she lets her head hang.

Jonas types, deletes, types again. He rubs his temple with the heel of his hand and drinks coffee that's too hot.

In the bathroom mirror, Lena wipes a circle through the steam. Her eyes are rimmed dark. She presses a finger to the spot between her eyebrows where the headache always starts.

She dresses in a rush, dragging jeans up over wet legs and a T-shirt over her head, trips on her shoes, catches herself on the counter, and laughs once at nothing.

Her phone lights up with a stack of notifications: EMAIL (17 NEW). RENT DUE. MISSED CALL: BOSS. "Don't forget to hydrate!" "Stand up!" "Breathe." DENTIST: REMINDER.

She turns it face down.

LENA
(quietly, to herself)
We can't keep doing this.

Jonas snaps the laptop shut and grabs his jacket.

JONAS
If we run, we make the train.

They look at each other across the room, a tired, practiced look, the one they give each other every morning. Then they run.

CUT TO:

SCENE 2

EXT. CITY STREETS - MORNING

Noise and heat. Bus brakes scream, a vendor shouts over a hiss of steam, and a siren threads through all of it. Lena and Jonas shoulder their way down the sidewalk against a crowd that doesn't apologize. A cyclist clips Jonas's arm.

CYCLIST (O.S.)
Watch it!

Jonas half turns, swallows what he was going to say, and keeps moving.

LENA
(breathless)
We should've left ten minutes ago.

JONAS
We always should've left ten minutes ago. Doesn't matter when we leave.

They go down into the subway, where the crowd thickens into one slow river of shoulders and backpacks and someone's perfume, too sweet. Jonas checks his watch and flinches.

JONAS (CONT'D)
If we miss

LENA
Don't say it.

They push through the turnstiles. On the platform a three-note chime sounds, rising, and the doors start to close. Jonas slips in. Lena wedges through as the doors kiss the back of her coat, and she lets out a shaky breath.

INT. SUBWAY CAR - CONTINUOUS

The car is packed. The fluorescent lights buzz at a pitch you can feel in your teeth. The train jerks forward and everyone leans together and rights themselves.

Lena grips the pole until her knuckles go white. Sweat beads at her hairline. The car smells like yesterday's coffee and someone's shampoo.

She looks up at the digital clock over the doors.

8:59
It flickers.

9:00
9:01

Then it's 8:59 again.

She looks at the dark window. Her reflection looks back at her, pale, and for a breath it doesn't move when she moves. Then it catches up.

Beside her, Jonas thumbs through his email, starts a reply, deletes it, and starts again with his jaw clenched.

The train roars into the tunnel, and the window goes black.

CUT TO:

SCENE 3

INT. OFFICE - DAY

An open-plan floor of ringing phones and flat, harsh light. The glass doors whoosh open, and Jonas hurries in with his jacket half on and his bag bouncing against his hip. A few heads lift and go back down.

He squeezes between desks, muttering "sorry" when he clips a chair, and drops into his seat. His desk is a mess of crooked papers, with yesterday's coffee ring still on the laminate. He tries to look like he's been there for an hour.

On his monitor, a banner ad flickers: STOP THE CLOCK.

He blinks. It's an ad for car insurance.

He rubs his eyes.

His BOSS (40s) leans over the partition.

BOSS

Do you know what time it is?

JONAS

I know.

BOSS

The quarterly analysis was due yesterday.

JONAS

You'll have it by end of day.

BOSS

(friendly, which is worse)

You said that yesterday.

(beat)

And you've been late all month.

That isn't like you.

The Boss smiles and moves on down the row. Jonas lets out a slow breath through his nose and turns back to his screen. The sentence he was writing doesn't make sense. He holds down the backspace key and watches it disappear one letter at a time until the page is empty.

Nearby, the printer jams with a loud clack. Jonas flinches. The machine resets with a long, low drone that goes on a little longer than it should.

A CO-WORKER passes and raps on his desk with a knuckle. Jonas nearly comes out of his chair.

CO-WORKER

You good?

JONAS

Great.

CO-WORKER

Meeting in twenty-five.

JONAS

Got it.

The co-worker is already gone. On the wall, the second hand of the office clock jerks forward, loud enough to hear over the phones. Jonas digs his nails into his palm.

INT. CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

A wall clock ticks too loudly over a glossy table. Jonas sits at the far end with his laptop open and a black notebook with a worn elastic band beside it. Colleagues talk over each other.

MANAGER (O.S.)

So let's push the dashboard review
to Thursday.

Jonas writes in the notebook in small square capitals, QUARTERLY - EOD, and draws a box around it. Then another box around that. Then a third.

A calendar notification slides onto his screen: CLIENT SYNC IN 25 MIN. Under it, just for a second, a second notification: FERRY DEPARTS - BOARDING NOW.

Then it's gone.

Jonas stares at the place where it was. He nods at something someone said. The clock ticks. He shuts the laptop a little too hard, and a couple of people look over.

CUT TO:

SCENE 4

INT. CREATIVE AGENCY - DAY

Another open-plan office. The wall calendar is a color-coded war map of sticky notes. Lena sits at her desk juggling browser tabs and Slack messages as the notifications pop up faster than she can close them.

PROJECT MANAGER (O.S.)

Lena, where's the Q3 deck?

Lena clicks through to a half-finished slide deck.

LENA

Almost there. I'm waiting on copy
from Alex.

PROJECT MANAGER (O.S.)
It was due yesterday. We've got the
client call in twenty. Just make
something up for now.

The Project Manager is gone before Lena can answer. Her phone
buzzes: ONE-ON-ONE WITH CFO @ 1:30. She silences it.

Across the room, a cheerful CO-WORKER sets a timer on her
phone.

CO-WORKER
Standup in fifteen!

Lena nods without looking up. Her fingers stay over the
keyboard and don't move.

CUT TO:

SCENE 5

INT. COFFEE SHOP - AFTERNOON

Lena sits at a wobbly table with her laptop open to a column
of red exclamation points and a coffee she hasn't touched.
Her phone rattles against the table. STRETCH! HYDRATE!
MINDFUL MINUTE? She swipes them away, and a text slides in.

ON SCREEN - TEXT THREAD

MOM: Don't forget your doctor appointment next Thursday at 8.

LENA: I know.

MOM: And dinner with your aunt Sunday. And you're still
helping Jenny move, right?

Lena starts typing a long reply. She deletes all of it
without sending. Another notification: URGENT: TEAM SYNC
RESCHEDULE.

She drops the phone face down.

The door chimes. A young couple comes in laughing, windblown,
looking like they've just come off a beach somewhere. Lena
watches them a little too long and then looks down.

A BARISTA sets a warm blueberry muffin on the table without
being asked.

BARISTA
On the house. You look like you
need it.

Lena looks up at her, surprised, and tries to smile, and mostly manages it.

CUT TO:

SCENE 6

INT. SUBWAY CAR - EVENING

The evening train is just as crowded. Lena stands wedged between strangers, still holding the paper bag from the coffee shop. The car lurches, and a man's backpack presses into her shoulder. She closes her eyes, then opens them on the row of ads above the windows.

One of them shows children jumping off a wooden dock into bright water, their arms and legs flung out, the sky white behind them. The tagline reads: ENDLESS LIGHT AWAITS.

The lights in the car flicker. When they come back, it's an airline ad for summer fares, the same children and the same dock, and different words.

The train slows and stops between stations. The lights dim.

ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

We are being held momentarily.

Thank you for your patience.

Around her, people sigh and check their watches. Somebody swears. Under all of it, the stopped train's motor idles in a long, low, steady drone that fills the car.

Lena's breathing is fast at first. Then it slows. It settles, without her deciding anything, into the rhythm of the drone. Her shoulders come down. For a moment, in a car full of people staring at their phones, she's the only one who looks calm.

The train jerks forward, and the drone breaks off. Lena looks almost disappointed. She realizes she has crushed the paper bag flat in her fist.

CUT TO:

SCENE 7

INT. APARTMENT - EARLY NIGHT

The small kitchen is crowded with takeout boxes, the pile of unopened mail, and two glasses of wine.

A cheap wall clock ticks over the table, loud in the small room, and every so often it seems to skip.

Jonas sits with his laptop open, not eating. Lena scrolls her phone, then tosses it face down.

LENA

We never see each other. We work,
we eat, we sleep, and then we get
up and do it again.

JONAS

What do you want me to do? Quit?
Let everything fall apart?

Lena doesn't answer. She looks at the pile of mail on the counter, at the red stripe on the top envelope. Jonas follows her eyes to it.

The fridge motor kicks on behind them with a low, steady hum under the ticking of the clock.

JONAS (CONT'D)

I'm doing the best I can.

LENA

I know. Me too.

Neither of them says anything for a while. Lena gets up and pours more wine with a heavy hand.

LENA (CONT'D)

(quietly, almost to
herself)

I don't know how much longer I can
do this.

Jonas stands up. He reaches over the table, takes the clock off its nail on the wall, and lays it face down on the counter. The ticking stops. Where it hung there's a single nail and a pale circle on the paint.

JONAS

Then maybe we shouldn't.

Lena looks at him. That isn't how he talks.

He closes the laptop and pushes it away across the table. She's never seen him do that.

CUT TO:

SCENE 7A**INT. APARTMENT - NIGHT**

Later. The takeout has gone cold. A houseplant is dying with dignity in the corner. City noise comes in through the window. Lena's phone pings. She checks it and puts it face down again.

Lena watches Jonas. Jonas watches nothing.

LENA

We can't live like this forever.

There's a moment where he could make a joke. He doesn't.

JONAS

I know.

LENA

Then what are we doing?

Jonas opens the laptop and turns it toward her. An article fills the screen: SOMMARØY: THE ISLAND WHERE TIME DOESN'T EXIST.

He scrolls through the photos for her. The midnight sun sitting on a flat silver sea. A bonfire with blurred faces around it. Children jumping off a wooden dock into bright water. Lena leans in and looks at that one for a long time.

Under the city noise, faint, there's the sound of waves breaking. They're hundreds of miles from any sea. Neither of them notices.

JONAS

What if we just stopped?

LENA

Stopped what?

JONAS

All of it. The alarms. The trains.
The deadlines.

(beat)

What if we left?

Lena holds very still, because if she moves, she's going to cry.

CUT TO:

SCENE 7B**INT. APARTMENT - LATE NIGHT**

The wine bottle is half gone. They sit on the floor with their backs against the couch and their knees pulled up, close but not touching, talking in the low voices people use after they've already said too much.

LENA

It's insane. People don't just leave.

JONAS

Some people do. There was a whole article.

It gets half a laugh out of her. She looks at the dark window, at the city lights.

LENA

What if we hate it there?

JONAS

Then we hate it together.

He doesn't say it like a joke. Lena rubs her forehead.

LENA

We don't even know how to start.

JONAS

We book it. Tomorrow. Before one of us gets sensible.

Lena reaches for his hand, tentatively, and he takes it.

LENA

Okay.

She leans in until her forehead is against his. Then she kisses him, slowly, and he kisses her back, and they slide down onto the floor together, clumsy and laughing, holding on.

CUT TO:

SCENE 7C